

GOVERNANCE AT THE DOORSTEP
A Delhi resident pays tax through a government portal

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formed the process of obtaining building permits. By providing an efficient and citizen-friendly platform, the OBPS has reduced processing time and increased transparency," Gupta gushes. ■

Online grievance redressal portals have increased transparency; **mobile apps by urban bodies** have made services more accessible

other duties for individuals and businesses has become much easier with secure online payment gateways. Land records—a domain often criticised for opacity and inefficiency—have undergone a digital overhaul. By digitising cadastral maps (that represent land parcels) and property transaction records, urban bodies have made property dealings more transparent. Another transformative facet of e-governance has been the new life given to grievance redressal. Today, urban bodies offer online portals where citizens can log complaints and monitor their status in real time. Online application tracking systems for citizens applying for services like birth and death certificates, trade licences or water connections constitute another milestone.

The adoption of mobile apps by urban bodies has made essential services more accessible. For instance, Mumbai's BMC mobile app allows citizens to pay property taxes, report grievances and access a range of municipal services. Delhi's municipal corporation portal provides a similar suite of services, while the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike has introduced a citizen engagement platform where individuals can participate in decision-making and provide feedback. Indeed, transparency is a hallmark of digital reforms. Municipalities now maintain online transparency portals, offering citizens insights into budgets, expenditures and project updates.

E-governance services not only enhance quality of life but also contribute to India's larger goal of creating smart cities and fostering economic growth. Its essence was communicated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi: "E-governance is easy, effective and economical. It is also environment-friendly. Paperless offices will benefit the environment." For the country as a whole, this can only be a win-win situation. ■